recognition, though you may need to do some hands-on coding to enable recognising local number plates for India given the urge for some of us to "pimp up" our number plates. There are more plugins available and enough documentation for you to come up with your own plugins.

An ordinary web camera

If you've got the proper drivers installed then iSpy will pick up a feed immediately and that's all you need from your camera manufacturer's side. Ensure any power saving features like auto-shutdown are turned off. And utilising more than one software for the same hardware might cause problems with the feed.

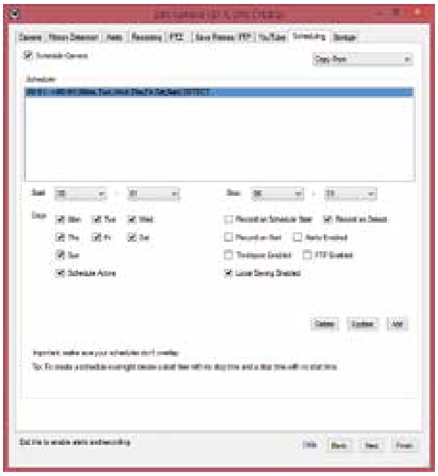
A computer

The hardware requirements for a basic 4 camera setup consists of a Windows OS(64-bit version would be preferred for a setup with more than 6 cameras running at 320x240 resolution), 2GB RAM, and an Intel i3 processor. The more cameras you add the greater your requirements will be and increasing the resolution of the video feed also requires more resources. If you have a setup with all cameras pulling full HD content then be prepared to switch to an i5 or greater. Don't worry about your computer crashing as you add more cameras the software limits the amount of CPU cycles it can consume so if the load on the processor is too much then it will scale down the resolution and wait for the CPU load to go below the threshold. But if you do have more than one unused computers lying around then you can assign a few cameras to each machine thus distributing the load. Hard drive space depends upon the amount of cameras connected and the configuration since an "always on" setup would require much more storage space than one triggered by motion sensing. And as always the resolution of each camera too matters.

Setting it up

1. Plug in your web camera and install the drivers for your OS.
2. Download iSpy and install it with all the plugins that you'd be needing. Avoid unnecessary plugins if you are never going to be using them.

Set alerts for when the camera is triggered



Setup a schedule for the system to turn on

Tweak the motion detection parameters

3. If you wish to connect to microphones and cameras that are hooked to other devices then you'll need iSpy Server installed.
4. Setup your web login if you wish to access the cameras remotely or on the same network. Remote access over the internet requires you to obtain the basic "iSpy Connect" subscription costing $7.95, which goes towards running a server through which your content will be streamed. You could get around this by working on the source code which they've graciously provided on their website but for the amount they are charging that hardly seems worth the effort.
5. Click on the Add button in the main interface and select the camera which you wish to monitor. Once you click on OK you'll be provided with another window where you get to adjust the parameters of your camera like the resolution at which it will record, the directory where you get to store the recorded stream. For features like motion capture and facial recognition you can set the sensitivity so as to remove ambient movement beyond the trigger threshold or else you'll have an always on camera. If you wish to focus on just a small region of the entire scene then you can drag a box around it and all the algorithms will apply to just that little area.
6. Other than recording the stream once motion is detected, iSpy can even send you an SMS, an email alert or even a tweet. Since carrier charges are incurred the SMS feature is offered as an add-on to a normal subscription.
7. For PTZ(Pan Tilt Zoom) cameras you can set the cameras to follow an object when it is detected, thus, allowing you to cover a wider canvas using just one device.
8. The storage is local primarily but you can upload your captured streams to your youtube account so that manual management of the recorded material is not required. It's more essential for high-value establishments. Then again, these establishments would likely go for a professional setup which can be held accountable.
9. That's it. Now while away while your surveillance system keeps an eye out for you and lets you know whenever anything worthwhile is detected.